

their ire was definitely targeted at extreme couponers. For the first time in my long history of using coupons, I saw a qualifier added to the use of a brand's coupons. The newest Procter & Gamble coupons had additional wording in small print at the bottom: *"Limit of four like coupons in same shopping trip. Coupons not authorized if purchasing products for resale."* Did this mean I could expect the Procter & Gamble coupon police to raid my next garage sale if I included some extra stockpiled items?

Despite a renewed interest in coupon use that corresponded with the downturn in the economy, there are still many packaged-goods marketers and retailers who would like to see paper coupons go the way of the dinosaur, viewing them as annoying or wasteful. And they do have a valid concern. Dealing with the distribution and redemption of coupons has typically been a complicated, costly, and inefficient process.

Even today, coupon processing includes hand counting or gross weighting millions of pieces of paper of varying sizes, often by agents that ship the coupons to clearinghouses in Mexico, where workers sort and scan for hours each day. For those workers, coupons might mean a job, but it is a job that is a literal pain in the neck while they stand in an assembly line, hand sorting and scanning upwards of ten thousand coupons a day. Coupons are counted at least twice, sometimes three times, by various parties. Then there are the time-consuming and expensive discrepancies, adjustments and negotiations among supermarkets, manufacturers, and the redemption agents.

Despite their inherent messiness, consumers aren't about to give up on a mode of savings that is so much under their control. After all, the price